

Weekly Reading Reflections #7: Sergio Monterroso

Assessing Dahlonega's Markers

- Marker 1: General Store
- Marker 2: General Service (Price's Law Office)
- Marker 3: Questionable Phrasing ("Youth" Club)
- Marker 4: General Service (Courthouse)
- Marker 5: Out-of-date Inscription (Not updated for new wars)

What did you know about this local history?

I'm not from Dahlonega or the Northeast Georgia area, so very little of this local history is known to me besides the brief research I did on Colonel Price. I had known that Price owned a law firm in Dahlonega and was involved in the construction of buildings like a church near the square. For Marker 5, I figured that Dahlonega's history would be centered on military admiration because of UNG being a military college — but now I wonder which came first: the college's military environment or Dahlonega's military admiration. UNG was founded after the Civil War and used frequently for Confederate memorials, so one question I'd ask is

What questions did it raise about Dahlonega?

I'm curious why the individuals memorialized in these markers were selected. Of the names given, I recognize only Colonel Price and know of his disturbing history. My assumption that the others recognized similarly to him may have their own unfortunate histories too. This could be a project for another student that takes this class, in which case I would recommend reviewing Confederate army lists on the National Archives and Records Administration, as well as local history newspapers to see whether these individuals attended Confederate memorial events that were frequently hosted on college grounds or within the square.

Why was this something worth commemorating for the square?

Marker 1 just reads like a store that was used to call back to a "golden age" of Dahlonega. Nostalgia is a powerful device in history that frequently is used to pull on heartstrings on members of the public. Awkward history is never sought after by tourists, and they may even avoid it when it's in front of their faces like people still do when they're confronted with uncomfortable evidences. Still, this may be me reading this plaque too harshly.

Marker 2 is mostly about Colonel Price than the actual law office that is being recognized in it. I doubt that Price was the first or last law firm to be stationed on the Dahlonega square — but what makes it different is Price himself. Price is hailed as a deity in local history in Dahlonega because of his work in Congress, the state assembly, and with the University of North Georgia; but what work is that? My brief research found that Price is accused of writing the provision in law that segregated public schools after a new

Constitution was adopted during his stay in the Georgia assembly. Is this what we venerate?

Me and John specifically posed to get the trash can that sits below Marker 3 as an ironic juxtaposition — the marker dedicated to a marksmanship “youth club” in an era marked by American white supremacy, now just sitting above a trash can where that ideology belongs. Again, I could be reading too far into this marker. Maybe this youth club of manly marksmanship established in the middle of the 20th century in the deep Blue Ridge hills was not racist at all? Possibilities are endless... but would a club like that get a recognition from the town? These markers come because the area was significant in the town, and the decision of whether it was significant comes by judging how people of the past took that area. I assume an integrated firing club would not have done well in Dahlonega, so it wouldn’t be “significant” in its time.

Marker 4 is used to mark the importance of the Dahlonega square as an area of governance, public transaction of commerce, and expression of speech without transgression by government. On their face alone, these are very respectable items to commemorate on a local city plaque — but history is deeper than face value. My project work before I took on Longstreet involved reading dozens of newspaper articles advertising Confederate memorial services taking place on the square. The impregnable forces of liberty being surrounded by an ideology driven by hate serves as a reminder that government belongs to this group only, public commerce belongs to this group only, and (most egregious of all) only this group has the right to speech.

What markers would you add?

A project needs to be undertaken to address the smaller voices in the largely local history of Dahlonega. These markers are reflective of old historical methodology of looking only towards those that “controlled” the narrative instead of those that lived under it. History is best served by looking at the variety of opinions, actions, and beliefs instead of what the leading class did. Critical history is required.



Marker 1

Title: "Dahlonega Stories"

Text: "In 1935 W.A. Whitmire tore down an earlier frame structure and erected this building as a general merchandise store. When Don and Mary Miller purchased the property in 1976, they remodeled it as Mary's Mini-Mall and rented to a number of shops over the years, including The Gold Shop since 1977. The Millers' Golden Memories shop passed to their daughter Judy Boggs and was renamed The Bear's Den in 2003."



Marker 2

Title: "Dahlonega Stories"

Text: "The Price Building was erected in 1897 by former Congressman W. P. Price to house Price & Son General Merchandise downstairs and Colonel Price's law offices upstairs. Later leased to various businesses, it was Dahlonega's first movie theater 1925-1948. Hal and Carol Williams purchased and rehabilitated the structure in 1981 to house a Christmas shop. In 2001 Sam and ____ Norton remodeled the downstairs as the ____ & Picnic Cafe."



Marker 3

Title: "'A frame building known as 'The Market House' was located on this site by the 1840s. In 1941 Woodmen of the World purchased the Dahlonega Post Office on the ground level and W.O.W. member Carl Southwell drew the plans for the building. W.O.W. Lodge 1374 created a firing range in the

basement to train local youth in marksmanship. An addition to the rear of the building provided storage for wheel chairs and other health care equipment loaned out by the organization. After the Post Office moved to a new location in 1965, the W.O.W. rented the downstairs for shops, including King's Clothing and Margaret Owens's "Antiques of Dahlonega." Kathy Aerts purchased the business in 1997 and renamed it "Cranberry Cornerse". Two large store racks used for sorting mail in the post office were used to display merchandise."



Marker 4

Title: "Lumpkin Court House"

Text: "This court house, built in 1836, replaced the small log structure used since the establishment of Lumpkin County in 1832. The town was named Dahlonega in October, 1833, for the Cherokee word 'Tahlonga' meaning 'golden'. From its steps in 1849, Dr. M. F. Stephenson, assayer at the Mint, attempted to dissuade Georgia miners from leaving to join the California gold rush. His oration gave rise to the sayings: 'There's millions in it,' and 'Thar's gold in them thar hills.'



Marker 5

Text: "In memorial [to] Lumpkin County Veterans of all wars 1775 -- 1987

Presented by the [Unintelligible] of Lumpkin County and Dahlonega-Lumpkin County V.F.W. Post 5533

1987."